

AI harming the environment argument doesn't make sense to me at all.

Posted by u/pewisamood • 0 points • 9 comments

I know these points are made a lot but they just have to again. Do anti's think water Burns and goes away forever? Do they not realize water gets constant to recycled? Water isn't like Gasoline, the WATER CYCLE EXISTS. Were they not taught that in literally elementary school?

Comments

u/Unfair_Scar_2110 • 1 points • 2025-06-15 14:01 UTC

You do know what a drought is and how it takes energy to reclaim water?

<https://news.mit.edu/2025/explained-generative-ai-environmental-impact-0117>

Any human activity will have some type of environmental impact.

u/phillipaframe • 1 points • 2025-06-15 12:53 UTC

Training AI needs lots of computational power and thus electricity. Also, when millions of users to use AI (i.e. AI overview in google search engine) every day, the electricity demand and CO2 emissions are enormous. For me, I will use AI if I need. But I hate those companies forcing me to use it, just like the AI overview in google search.

u/SaudiPhilippines • 1 points • 2025-06-15 07:16 UTC

Please research. The reason why the environment point is brought up a lot is because of the data centers in water-stressed areas. You see, it's true that the water cycle exists. Water, when used, doesn't disappear forever. The issue is the scarcity in water you can *use*. Usage includes but isn't limited to human consumption and agriculture.

Data centers often cool down their servers by using groundwater from the area. That wouldn't be much of a problem unless such an area is prone to droughts. An example is California. We all know Silicon Valley is a hotspot for technological innovation. Many data centers reside there. Given California's climate, air alone isn't enough to cool down servers. So, water sourced locally is often used, which in turn is also sourced from the Californian reservoirs.

The problem is, California often experiences drought. This means that water is vulnerable to being scarce. The water used to cool data centers in California just adds to the stress it is already experiencing. Why not ocean water? Or rainwater? Ocean water can corrode technology and the organisms within it can cause biofouling, where biological substances (e.g. algae) build up, reducing

efficiency and causing damage. Also, Cali primarily experiences rain only in certain seasons. It's dry and hot overall.

Water scarcity is a real issue. The antis make a fair point in bringing it up. The only thing most of them are missing is that AI is a recent technology that doesn't make up a large proportion of the energy use enough to be extremely concerned about. Training models is the most energy intensive part of AI, and no one is training models every day. Inference then, relative to training the model itself, is David to Goliath.

u/SaudiPhilippines • 1 points • 2025-06-15 07:20 UTC

The solution to the increased stress added by AI is not purging AI. Another will just come to take its spot. The solution is to find environmentally concerned ways to optimize cooling and make more out of less. It's also worth noting that the water used for cooling data centers can't always return in a readily usable state.

u/sevenbrokenbricks • 1 points • 2025-06-15 02:18 UTC

It costs us some amount of work to make some amount of water usable. Yes, that water will go back into the water cycle once used, and it'll be the same water we gather in the future, but in order to gather it again we need to do that amount of work again. This is elementary school stuff.

u/Disastrous-Pay6395 • 1 points • 2025-06-14 14:58 UTC

So how does water scarcity ever happen? Why are there droughts in the world?

u/pewisamood • 1 points • 2025-06-14 17:48 UTC

I didn't say they didn't happen. I'm saying ai isn't such a massive contributor antis say it is

u/Disastrous-Pay6395 • 1 points • 2025-06-14 18:02 UTC

I don't want to argue because it's against the rules but I'm curious to read more about this.

Most anti-AI people are concerned about water scarcity, which is a real issue. Not every where in the world has free access to clean water: people live in deserts or areas with pollution or other environmental hazards.

Can you share with me the study about this? I'd love to read more details about why they're wrong.

u/ofBlufftonTown • 2 points • 2025-06-14 03:28 UTC

AI may not be the cause of such production, but there's plenty of industrial forms of water wastage which render it polluted or recaptured only under circumstances which will render it seawater. That may not be the problem here, but you shouldn't base the argument on industrial water wastage and contamination not existing. You should base it on such systems never being used for AI.

u/pewisamood • 1 points • 2025-06-14 04:10 UTC

That's fair I didn't mean for it to come off that way. Of course there's actual water pollution

u/ofBlufftonTown • 1 points • 2025-06-14 15:03 UTC

Right and I think the production of AI does involve some such water wastage, at the same time as the water is being wasted for other tasks people feel ok with, such as google searches. A bundle of online activities are powered by these same water-

wasting activities, not only AI, but AI as part of it. That's not a crazy objection because it's true.

u/Old_Introduction7236 • 2 points • 2025-06-14 01:36 UTC

The most bizarre thing to me is seeing people act like clean water isn't a renewable resource so they can rant about AI being bad for the environment.

u/Andrew_42 • 3 points • 2025-06-13 17:14 UTC

The obvious response is that AI's impact isn't nearly as severe as it is being portrayed.

That said, the fact that water does in fact participate in a larger cycle does not mean that the use of that water can't have more immediate local consequences.

It's not that concern about industrial water use is *fundamentally* ridiculous, but rather that AI isn't the boogeyman it is often presented as.

If AI was really *that* bad for local water access, Nestlé would have been all over AI from the beginning.

u/Fearless_Future5253 • 2 points • 2025-06-13 10:57 UTC

They already debunked the one bottle every paragraph, but antis are scared no one will commission for their fetish artworks when you can use loras.

u/After-Fly-6859 • 2 points • 2025-06-13 09:55 UTC

Remember how they were telling us that every prompt cost X amount of bottles of water, as if bottled is water's most natural form

u/Amethystea • 1 points • 2025-06-13 19:57 UTC

Tangent fact: Bottled water has more micro and nano plastic than tap water.

u/Outrageous_South4758 • 5 points • 2025-06-12 17:00 UTC

Antis may be seemingly too old for having it on elementary school

u/megasean3000 • 8 points • 2025-06-12 15:28 UTC

I've no idea how antis think. The same power used in data centres is the same used in power plants all over the world.

u/GlitteringTone6425 • 4 points • 2025-06-12 15:16 UTC

the data centers were getting built anyways

the environmental issues with AI are due to the scale of data centers needed for online AI use, not some innate supernatural evil of the AI. Companies that rely on IT need data centers AI or not, they're just dedicating them to this new thing rather than the million old things.

u/Maxwell--the--cat • 14 points • 2025-06-12 14:29 UTC

And many datacenters are in regions with much water. And if you're not going to use AI because "it uses too much water" then you shouldn't use the internet at all